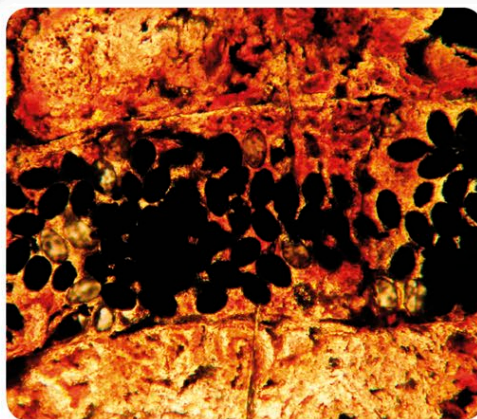


The largest known coprolite is 12 in (30 cm) long and is thought to have belonged to a *T. rex*.

Fossilized dung is difficult to find because it often rapidly breaks down and can look like a normal rock.



LOOKING INSIDE

Paleontologists are able to get more information about coprolites using microscopes and scanners. This image shows a microscopic view of a shark coprolite from the Paleozoic Era. The presence of unatched tapeworm eggs shows that this parasite was present in the creature's intestines.

Coprolite clues

Paleontologists need evidence to identify coprolites. Fossilized dung of ancient aquatic predators often contains fish bones, while the plant pollen in some poop helps experts date the specimens. Fragments of bone and muscle found in the prehistoric dung of some theropods suggest that food passed quickly through their digestive system. However, determining which prehistoric creature a coprolite belonged to is a harder task.

